

All of a sudden, an ordinary trip to the convenience store is about to take a hard turn. Now while the characters browse the aisles picking up drinks and snacks for their party, the players tense up more and more, knowing that at any minute some armed bad guys are going to come bursting in and change the night in a big way. And the longer it takes, the more the tension rises....

Follow the Players' Interest

As discussed in the character creation section, character sheets are basically code for what type of stories a particular player is interested in seeing during a chronicle. A player who creates a master swordswoman wants to get in swordfights; a player who creates a genius scientist wants to use her acumen to solve problems and have amazing breakthroughs, and so on. However, reading and understanding what players are interested in doesn't end with character sheets — it's important to keep track of what they're focused on during play as well.

Game sessions are a very limited, very focused period of time, so it's important for Storytellers to notice what players pay the most attention to during a chapter. As a rule of thumb, it's always easier to get players engaged and entertained if the story follows their interest, rather than trying to drag them away from something they like in pursuit of something they're not as engaged in. If the players were "supposed" to be talking to the bouncer during a club scene, but are having more fun talking to the bartender, maybe the bartender is actually the one who has the information they need. Or perhaps the bouncer gives them useful details for their current mystery, but the bartender becomes a regular contact for the group in the future, maybe even a romantic interest for one of the single characters.

This isn't to say that every passing whim of the players must be indulged at the expense of careful preparation or focus, merely that it's generally a good idea to take note of the story elements the players enjoy and play them up when possible. Doing so makes the players feel intimately connected to the world of the story, and gives them tangible rewards for their attention and participation, which is a powerful draw all its own.

Preparation & Record Keeping

Some Storytellers work extensively from prepared notes, with plenty of ready maps and supporting character writeups for every session, while others prefer a more freeform style, starting with a basic idea of where they want the session to go and then making it up as the players go along. A lot of Storytelling is improvisation, it's true, as both players and stories are notoriously unpredictable. However, as any good improvisational actor will tell you, improvising well actually takes a surprising amount of planning, and Storytellers of all styles can benefit from this advice.

Before a session begins, the Storyteller should take some time and try to anticipate where the story might go — not just the most obvious path, but at least one or two possible alternative routes the players might explore. What happens if

the players manage to talk their way out of the climactic fight scene, for example? Or what if the players (wrongly) guess the identity of the killer in the first scene and skip right to a confrontation instead of doing more investigation? It's not possible or necessary to try to think of every potential twist, of course, but giving a couple of possible scenarios some thought can mean the difference between keeping the story going and having things grind to a halt due to an unexpected decision.

Likewise, keeping records as the chronicle advances is an excellent idea, especially if the group cannot meet regularly. No matter how compelling the story or how interested the players are, there will eventually come a time when it's time to reference a previously-established supporting character or a sinister company the players encountered a while back, and a glance around the table reveals no one remembers the name in question.

That's when written notes come in handy for players and Storytellers alike. Notes don't need to be elaborate, just a record of a name and some pertinent details to remember, though of course more involved notes can be very helpful as well. If keeping track during play is slowing things down, a Storyteller can consider asking for player assistance, perhaps even designating a scribe to keep notes. Many groups of players have at least one member who already takes notes of some kind during game, so it isn't too difficult to offer them a little incentive to do so for the good of the group as a whole.

As a final note, it's a good idea to avoid reading large sections of notes at the players, especially during a supposedly interactive scene like a conversation or a chase. Straight note reading can make things feel mechanical and remind the players they're playing a game when they should be feeling immersed in the story instead. So while it's fine to read a short description to set the scene now and then, especially for Storytellers who have trouble with such things on the fly, on the whole notes are best used as prompts and reminders as opposed to texts for monologues.

Turn Questions Around

At times, even the best, most well-prepared Storyteller runs into situations she didn't plan for — players are endlessly creative, after all, and that means they take actions or ask questions that simply can't be anticipated. One deceptively simple technique to handle situations like this is to simply turn a player's action or question around and ask him what he thinks would happen. Doing so immediately engages the player, and also provides some useful information for the Storyteller to work with as she decides what to do with this unexpected twist.

For instance, suppose a Storyteller has set up a murder mystery for her players, and during the investigation one of the group gets suspicious and decides he's going to follow a supporting character that was supposed to simply be a harmless bystander. It's not a situation the Storyteller has anticipated, but it's a perfectly fair course of action. So when the player asks, "I follow him home, where does he live?" the Storyteller replies, "I don't know, where do you think he lives?"